This reduces trial-and-error behavior and improves both efficiency and safety. The agent spends less time exploring invalid paths and is less likely to generate unnecessary or risky requests.

18.4.4 Policy as a source of guidance

This approach changes the role of policy in the system. In traditional authorization models, policy primarily serves as a gate. It evaluates requests and blocks those that violate defined rules. In a constraint-aware model, policy also serves as a guide.

Table 18.1 compares the reactive and constraint-aware approaches.

Table 18.1 Reactive authorization versus constraint-aware authorization in agent planning

Reactive authorization model	Constraint-aware authorization model
Agent proposes writing to any path	Agent queries allowed write paths first
PDP denies disallowed paths at runtime	PDP returns allowed path constraints during planning
Denial triggers replanning	Plan is formed within defined constraints
Higher frequency of runtime denials	Fewer runtime denials
Policy acts primarily as a gate	Policy acts as both boundary definition and gate

By exposing policy constraints during planning, the system enables the agent to reason within the boundaries defined by policy rather than discovering those boundaries through failure.

18.4.5 From control to collaboration

Constraint-aware authorization marks a shift from controlling agent behavior to collaborating with it. Instead of simply blocking unsafe actions, the policy system provides information that helps the agent make better decisions. The agent remains flexible and adaptive, yet its behavior is shaped by the same policy framework that governs the rest of the system.

At ACME, this approach improved both efficiency and predictability. Agents generated fewer failed requests, completed tasks more directly, and operated more consistently within defined boundaries.